



The World Cup

More than just football?

Every four years, one competition stops the world. It means more than the score.



Listen to the article

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Fans celebrate as the World Cup trophy is lifted in a full stadium.

WARM-UP

Talk about the questions with a partner.

1. Do you watch the World Cup?
Which team do you like?
2. Why can sport bring people together?

USEFUL LANGUAGE

I watch... with...

Sport brings people together because...

Every four years, something strange happens. For one month, people who never play football sit in front of screens at home, in cafés and in city squares. Strangers hug after a goal. A whole country stops to watch one game. The World Cup is football, but it is also much more.

No other event is this big. About half the world watches some part of it, and more than a billion people may watch the final. Part of it is the show: the colors, the noise, the last-minute penalty. And part of it is that the **fans** care so much.

But to **host** the World Cup is very expensive. A country spends billions of dollars on a new **stadium**, hotels and trains. Sometimes this is good, and people use the new metro for years. Sometimes it is not, and the stadium is almost empty after the last game.

So who pays the **cost**? Often it is ordinary people, and sometimes for many years. But others say the country feels **proud**, the world learns its name, and for one month borders seem a little smaller. Both of these things can be true at the same time.

For one month every four years, the whole world watches the same thing. Why does that still matter?

VOCABULARY

A. Match the words (1–5) with the meanings (A–E).

- | | |
|--------------|---|
| 1. host — | A. to have a big event in your country |
| 2. fans — | B. the money you must pay for something |
| 3. stadium — | C. happy because you or your country did well |
| 4. cost — | D. people who love a team or a sport |
| 5. proud — | E. a big building where people watch sport |

TRUE OR FALSE

Read the sentences. Circle T (True) or F (False).

- | | | |
|---|---|---|
| 1. About half the world watches some of the World Cup. | T | F |
| 2. Every new stadium is full after the tournament. | T | F |
| 3. The article says hosting is always a good idea. | T | F |
| 4. Hosting the World Cup costs billions of dollars. | T | F |
| 5. Some people say the World Cup brings the world together. | T | F |

DISCUSSION

USEFUL LANGUAGE I think... · For me... · because... · It depends.

- 1 Do you enjoy big sporting events? Why or why not?
- 2 Has a match ever brought your family or your country together?
- 3 Why do people feel so strongly about their national team?
- 4 Is it worth billions of dollars to host the World Cup?
- 5 Does the World Cup bring the world together, or divide it?

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01 CRITICAL THINKING

WAS IT WORTH IT?

Five things a country got when it hosted the World Cup. Was the money well spent?

Work in a group. Mark every line **WORTH IT**, **NOT SURE** or **NOT**. Your group must agree, and be ready to say who paid.

WHAT THEY GOT	FIVE YEARS LATER	WORTH IT	NOT SURE	NOT
A \$200 million stadium	Beautiful. Now a small team plays there, and it is nearly empty.	☐	☐	☐
A new metro line	Built for the fans. Now local people use it every morning.	☐	☐	☐
40,000 jobs	Real work for two years. Most of the jobs ended after the final.	☐	☐	☐
The debt	People are still paying it. Some of them were children at the time.	☐	☐	☐
One national memory	A goal the whole country watched together. You cannot buy that.	☐	☐	☐

YOUR VERDICT Worth it in total? _____ Would you say yes for your own city? _____

- DISCUSS**
- 1 Can a memory be worth a debt that your children pay?
 - 2 Compare with another group. Who said yes for their own city, and why?

02 LANGUAGE IN CONTEXT

USE THE LANGUAGE

Complete the sentences with a word from the box.

stadium proud fans cost host

- 1 Thousands of _____ waited outside the ground.
- 2 Our city wants to _____ the next World Cup.
- 3 The new _____ can hold 60,000 people.
- 4 The _____ of the new trains was very high.
- 5 My parents were very _____ of me.

03 SPEAKING CHALLENGE

ROLE • TASK • PRESENT

Work in small groups. Follow the three steps.

ROLE You are a committee. Your city wants to host the World Cup.

TASK Choose two reasons your city is a good host. Decide who pays for the stadium.

PRESENT Tell the class your two reasons and say why your city should win.

USEFUL LANGUAGE

Our first reason is... · Our city has...
This is good because... · We think... should pay.

04 WRITING

YOUR OPINION

Should a country spend billions of dollars to host the World Cup?

Write 60–100 words. Use words from the article.

USEFUL LANGUAGE

I think a country should... · The first reason is... · For example,... · But... · So I think...